hogi. Ye kisanon ko maar rahe hain...lekin hum kahin nahi jaane wale (We won't vacate the protest site. We'll talk to the government, the laws will be repealed. They are killing the farmers, but we won't go back)," said a teary eyed Rakesh Tikait. The emotional address went viral on social media across western Uttar Pradesh and elsewhere. Farmers who were halfway back home turned back their carts and tractors and were soon heading back to the protest sites. And they were now joined by thousands of others.

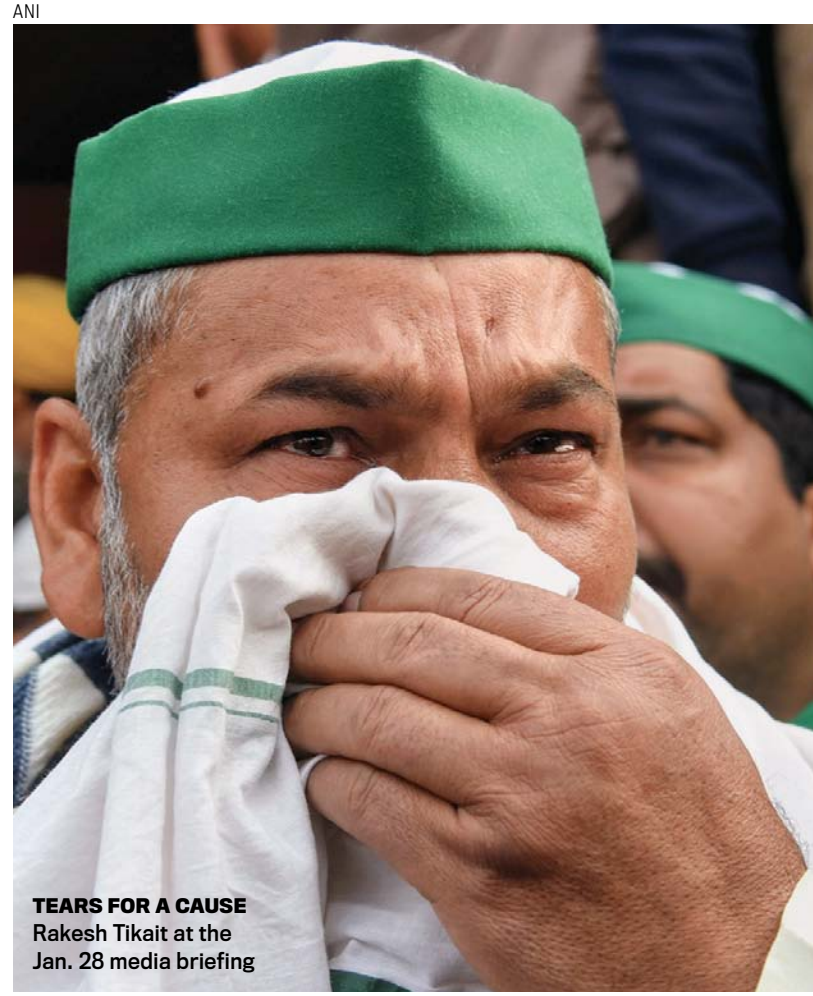
"Talks with the government failed 12 times after the protest started in November, but after January 28 it completely stopped. Maybe they (the government) felt that now they [the farmers] won't go back till the laws are repealed," says Rakesh. By March, protests had started in Moradabad, Pilibhit and even in Lucknow. Rakesh started travelling to several districts of UP and Haryana, and later to six other states where crowds gathered in huge numbers to hear him. "Even during the peak of the Covid second wave, when many farmers went back to their homes, the protests did not stop," he points out.

Months went by and the stalemate continued, but on October 3, a horrific incident in Lakhimpur, Pilibhit district, again left the central government in damage control mode. Union minister of state for home Ajay Mishra Teni's son allegedly plowed his car into a crowd of protesting farmers, killing six of them. Two more people died in the violence that ensued. Viral videos of the incident left the farmer com-

"I became emotional when I saw the way the police was manhandling our *annadatas*.... We were very clear from day one that we won't go back. '*Kanoon wapasi, ghar wapasi*' was our slogan"

"It was during Atal Bihari Vajpayee's regime...at a protest in Delhi over crop prices in June 2002, I locked the main entrance to Parliament. Vajpayee*ji* was in Parliament that day. The lock and chain, part of the evidence, are still there at the local *thana* where I was kept in jail"

ANI



TEARS FOR A CAUSE
Rakesh Tikait at the Jan. 28 media briefing